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Section Title(S): Marital And Non-Marital Sexual Behavior

Marital and Non-Marital Sexual Behavior

The !Kung have two rather different modalities for coitus, within the village, at night, and out in the bush, during the daytime. Sexual relations are not confined to married people, but sleeping together in the village at night is. Since the whole village sleeps around a circle of fires within easy earshot of one another, with married couples and their children sharing their few blankets or animal hides and their body heat for warmth, coitus in the village tends to be very restrained. Couples who are obviously having coitus in the village can expect to be teased about it later by their "joking" partners, but since some of the members of the village are likely to be "respect" relatives, in whose presence no sexual jokes should be made, it is not easy to integrate coitus into village life. The most important "respect" relations are the couples' own parents and own children, who are precisely the people who are likely to be closest to them in the sleeping arrangements of the village (Shostak 1976). It may occasionally happen that an unmarried couple will quietly get together within the village while others are asleep, but this is unlikely to be entirely unobserved. If the observer happens to be a relative of an absent spouse, for instance, a great fuss would surely be made.

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Premarital coitus and a range of sexual experiences after marriage take place outside of the village, in some quiet spot out in the bush where the couple is unlikely to be observed. The couple may leave the village together, ostensibly to gather food or go visiting another village, or may meet by prearrangement or chance out in the bush, always in the daytime. Since the !Kung are excellent trackers, recognize the footprints of other !Kung, and are usually interested in the location and activities of others, these discrete meetings often come to be public knowledge. Married couples who want a more uninhibited opportunity

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for sexual relations than the village offers may go to the bush together. While the couple has a nursing child (who accompanies the mother everywhere), these opportunities are limited for the mother. Couples who have not yet had a child, and those whose children are old enough to be left in the village, may have sexual relations in the bush as often as they wish. Unmarried couples (including couples who are both married, but not to each other) have intercourse out in the bush; if they decide that they like each other on the basis of these experiences, they may marry. "Affairs" are unlikely to be long-lasting, because someone is likely to learn of it and object, especially if one or both of the parties is already married. When members of the same living group risk sexual jealousy by having  232 nonmarital sexual relations, the group as a whole may split into warring factions. It is more common for "affairs" to be conducted with members of other living groups, nearby, or those to which one comes as a visitor.

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